

Through this connection to rest, Noah’s role in the story is previewed and given a theological interpretation. God brings rest and comfort to his world through Noah’s obedient actions and role as the surviving remnant in the flood generation.

Rest (נוח) is a major theological theme in the TaNaK for describing the restoration of Eden conditions on Earth as in Heaven. When God brings rest, it involves restoring a realm of order and sacred space where God can dwell with his people (see Deut. 3:20, 12:10; Josh. 1:13, 21:44; 2 Sam. 7:1, 11; 1 Kgs. 5:18).

Comfort (נחם) is a major theme in the Prophets, especially in Isaiah, and it describes the era of restoration when the failure of God’s people is forgiven, their exile is over, and God renews his covenant with them in a restored Eden.

This points forward to Noah’s crucial act of worship and obedience as he emerges from the ark in Genesis 8:20-22. In the narrative arc of Genesis 2-9, Noah is placed before the reader as an image of the promised seed of Genesis 3:15.

Noah is the righteous seed who passes the test through obedience to God’s will, and he survives as a remnant through the waters of death to offer a precious sacrifice. This qualifies him to become the new humanity at the helm of a renewed creation that lives in a new covenant relationship with its creator.

Introduction to the Flood Narrative in Genesis 6:1-9:27

The flood narrative spans from Genesis 6:1 to Genesis 9:27, and it consists of 15 large literary units made of narrative and poetic materials. The flood narrative has been spliced into the end of Noah’s genealogy, which is now split into two parts in 5:32 and 9:28-29.

It also seems likely that 6:9-10 and 7:6 are a continuation of the genealogy in 5:32 and the natural bridge to the information in 9:28-29, which presents Noah’s total age at 958 years.

Topic	Verses
Genealogy Begins	Genesis 5:21-31 ²⁸ And Lemek lived one hundred and eighty-two years, and became the father of a son. ²⁹ Now he called his name Noah, saying, “This one will give us rest from our work and from the toil of our hands arising from the ground which the LORD has cursed.” ³⁰ And Lemek lived five hundred and ninety-five years after he became the father of Noah, and he had other sons and daughters. ³¹ So all the days of Lemek were seven hundred and seventy-seven years, and he died.
<i>Genealogy with Flood Narrative Inserted.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Topic		Verses
		And Noah was five hundred years old, and Noah became the father of Shem, Ham, and Japheth ...
Flood Narrative Begins		Genesis 6:1-8 ¹ When human beings began to increase in number on the earth and daughters were born to them ...
	Genealogy Inserted	Genesis 6:9-10 ⁹ These are the birth-generations of Noah; Noah was a righteous one, blameless in his generation; Noah walked with <i>Elohim</i> ; ...
Flood Narrative Continues		Genesis 6:11-7:5 ¹¹ Now the earth was corrupt in the sight of God, and the earth was filled with violence ...
	Genealogy Inserted	Genesis 7:6 ... and Noah was six hundred years old when the flood of water came upon the earth ...
Flood Narrative Ends		Genesis 7:7-9:27 ^{9:27} ... May God enlarge Japheth, and may he live in the tents of Shem; and may Canaan be his servant."
	Genealogy Ends	Genesis 9:28-29 ²⁸ ... And Noah lived after the flood, three hundred and fifty years after the flood. ²⁹ And all the days of Noah were nine hundred and fifty years, and he died.
<i>Genealogy with Flood Narrative Inserted. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

The arrangement of the text gives a clue to its meaning. The flood narrative is a long exposition of Lemek's promise in Genesis 5:29, which itself recalls God's promise in [Genesis 3:15-17](#). Noah is presented as the promised seed of the woman who will undo the curse. The question is, How? The flood narrative is designed to provide the answer.

Reflection Question

Since Adam and Eve had already sinned, do you think the sins of their children, such as Cain murdering Abel, were unavoidable?

Session 6: The Flood Narrative in Ancient Near Eastern Context

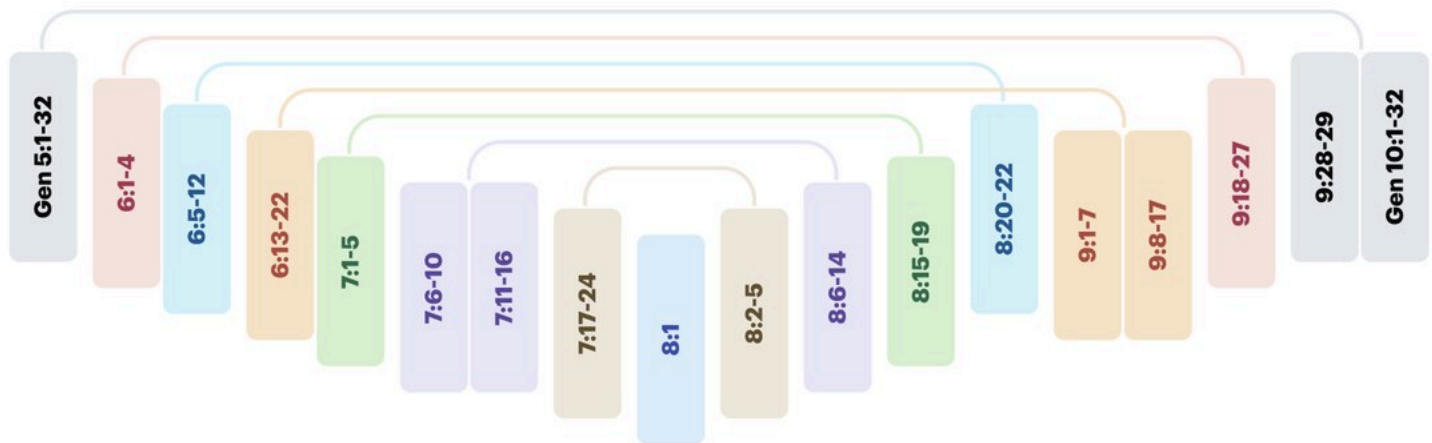
Key Takeaways

- Genesis 8:1 is a pivot from de-creation to new creation.
- The biblical flood story is designed to be in dialogue with the other ancient Near Eastern flood stories.
- The differences between the biblical account and other flood stories outline rival portraits of God.

The Macro-Design of the Flood Narrative

The composition of the flood narrative is complex because it seems to arrange more than one preexisting source (called “J” and “P” by Old Testament scholars). However, all of the preexisting material has been carefully arranged in a symmetrical design with doubled panels so that the story leads up to its climax in a two-step pattern and then roughly retraces the thematic development in reverse order.

The composition of the flood narrative has also been presented as an act of de-creation and re-creation modeled on Genesis 1, and so it has 10 divine speech acts just as in Genesis 1:1-2:3.



Horizontal Macrodesign of the Flood Story. Adapted from Teeter, Andrew (2019). "Genesis Class Notes." By BibleProject for Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Genesis 6-9					Divine Speeches
6:1-4: The Heavenly Rebellion (Take 1)					#1 - 6:3
6:5-12: The Earthly Rebellion (Take 2)					#2 - 6:7
6:13-22: Divine Speech of <i>Elohim</i> : 1st Warning of Flood (Take 1)					#3 - 6:13
7:1-5: Divine Speech of Yahweh: 2nd Warning of Flood (Take 2)					#4 - 7:1
7:6-10: Flood Begins and Noah Enters the Ark (Take 1)					
7:11-16: Flood Begins and Noah Enters the Ark (Take 2)					
7:17-24: The Flood Overwhelms the Land					
8:1: The Pivot: God Remembers Noah					
8:2-5: The Flood Recedes from the Land					
8:6-14: Noah Sends Out Birds To See if the Waters Have Dried Up					
8:15-19: Divine Speech: Noah to Leave the Ark					#5 - 8:15
8:20-22: Noah's Sacrifice Deals with the Earthly Rebellion					#6 - 8:21
9:1-7: Divine Speech: Blessing and Provision of Food					#7 - 9:1
9:8-17: Divine Speech: The Covenant for the Preservation of Life					#8 - 9:8 #9 - 9:12 #10 - 9:17
9:18-27: The Rebellion of Ham and Noah's Blessing and Curse					
Macrodesign of the Flood Story. Adapted from Teeter, Andrew (2019). "Genesis Class Notes." By BibleProject for Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).					

Major Features of the Design of the Flood Narrative

The story begins with a paired unit (6:1-4 and 6:5-12) about the crisis in Heaven and Earth that necessitates the flood. These two units are connected by vocabulary and theme: The inhabitants of Heaven and Earth disrupt cosmic order by violating the boundaries placed on them in Genesis 1-2.

Two Rebellions

The earthly rebellion (6:5-12) describes the ruin of the land and the corrupt condition of humanity that drives God to purify the land with a flood. This language is adopted in the story of Noah's sacrifice after the flood (8:20-22). God decides to change his strategy with corrupt humans by sustaining the cosmic order despite humanity's evil.

The heavenly rebellion (6:1-4) remains in the background of the flood narrative, but its language and themes are picked up in the concluding narrative of Ham's rebellion (9:18-27). Illicit sex and violation of boundaries bind the rebellious sons of *Elohim* to the sons of Ham, that is, the Canaanites.

Two Divine Speeches

The first divine speech warning Noah about the flood (6:13-22) introduces the themes of (1) the construction of the ark, (2) the call to enter it along with all the animals, (3) the promise of a covenant between God and Noah, and (4) the provision of food. The first two themes are developed immediately in following units (building and entering the ark with the animals), but the remaining two themes are not picked up until we come to the symmetrical pairs in 9:1-7 (the provision of food) and 9:8-17 (the covenant).

The second divine speech to enter the ark (7:1-5) corresponds to the first speech (6:13-22), but it differs in that Noah is called to take pure and impure animals into the ark and a timeline is given for the flood. In seven more days the flood will come, and it will rain for 40 days. This speech is paired with its symmetrical partner in 8:15-19, where Noah and the animals are called to leave the ark in precisely the language of their invitation to enter it.

Awaiting and Waiting Out the Flood

The narrative about Noah and the animals entering the ark (7:6-16) happens in two parallel panels, 7:6-10 and 7:11-16. Each unit begins by noting the age of Noah (600 years in 7:6 and 7:11) and how he entered the ark with the animals (the pure ones in 7:8 and the Gen. 1 list in 7:14). These two units match the narrative of Noah's patient waiting for the waters of the flood to dry up (8:6-14). Noah's age is noted again (601 years in 8:13). He employs two birds (one pure and one impure) and waits through multiple stages of seven days.

The description of the flood's arrival and overwhelming power in 7:17-24 leads to the climactic statement that only Noah and those with him in the ark "remained" (7:23). The waters surge until they cover the mountains (7:19-20). Corresponding to this is the multistage recession of the waters in 8:2-5 as the mountains become visible again.

Genesis 8:1 is at the center of the entire unit. God remembers Noah and causes his wind to blow upon the flood waters so they recede.

Here is a more detailed chart highlighting repeated phrases that link symmetrical units in Genesis 6:1-9:27.

Genesis 6-9

6:1-4: The Heavenly Rebellion (Take 1)

- Sons of *Elohim* take daughters of humanity = illicit sex

6:5-12: The Earthly Rebellion (Take 2)

- Human heart is bad / the land is ruined

6:13-22: Divine Speech of *Elohim*: 1st Warning of Flood (Take 1)

- Noah to build the ark
- God is sending flood, but will set up a covenant with Noah
- Noah to enter ark with family and animals, 2 of each kind
- Noah to gather food
- "Noah did all that *Elohim* commanded him" (6:22)

7:1-5: Divine Speech of Yahweh: 2nd Warning of Flood (Take 2)

- Noah to enter ark with his household
- Noah to take pure animals (7 each) and impure animals (2 each)
- In 7 days, rain will come for 40 days
- "Noah did all that Yahweh commanded him" (7:5)

7:6-10: Flood Begins and Noah Enters the Ark (Take 1)

- Noah is 600 years old
- Flood of waters comes upon the land
- Noah and family enter the ark
- Animals come two by two to Noah, into the ark
- "just as *Elohim* commanded Noah" (7:9)

7:11-16: Flood Begins and Noah Enters the Ark (Take 2)

- Noah is 600 years old
- Heaven and deep burst open, rain upon the land
- Noah and family enter the ark
- Pure and impure animals come two by two to Noah, into the ark
- "just as Yahweh commanded him" (7:16a)
- "and Yahweh closed behind him" (7:16b)

7:17-24: The Flood Overwhelms the Land

- 7:17-20: The waters are great and mighty over the land and mountains
- 7:21-22: Everything dies (Take 1)
- 7:23-24: Everything dies (Take 2)
- Noah in the ark is left as a remnant

Macrodesign of the Flood Story Expanded. Adapted from Teeter, Andrew (2019). "Genesis Class Notes." By BibleProject for Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).